could be perceived by Indian Muslims as an Islamic victory over the Soviets in Afghanistan.

Reddy and Ashfaq, however, argued that Indian Muslims had no traction with Pakistan and Afghanistan Muslim outfits and moreover the R&AW had informed Rajiv Gandhi that Moscow under Gorbachev was already looking for a political settlement for the Afghan issue.

'We were more worried about Lt General Hamid Gul's rhetoric against India than some mundane diplomatic issue. The Pakistani general had taken over as the new ISI chief in March 1987 and our agents had confirmed that General Gul was preparing a separate batch of terrorists to be launched in Jammu and Kashmir, armed with weapons provided by the USA for Afghan mujahideen. The USA had started supplying deadly missiles to Pakistan for the Afghan insurgents and the fear of them being used against India during any future conflict was heightened/ Reddy told me.

A Pashtun, General Hamid Gul hated India's military dominance in South Asia. Gul's first move as ISI chief, Ashfaq said, was to provide massive finances and weapons to Gulbuddin Hekmatyar to launch an offensive against the Soviet troops and help the ISI run agents in Afghanistan for subversive activities. Gul also tried to get cosy with Massoud, but the warrior, faithful to the Indian intelligence agency, snubbed his overtures.

As a matter of policy, we did not try to recruit Hekmatyar, who was ready to sell himself to the highest bidder. We had told the R&AW chief, A.K. Verma, that Hekmatyar, a Salafi, wouldn't be loyal to us. We could do things in Afghanistan without